

THE MIDWESTERNER

STATE

Bipartisan effort to protect privacy as Flock cameras spread across state

Proposed legislation comes amid a widespread public backlash against the technology in Michigan and beyond

BY VICTOR SKINNER | SEPTEMBER 25, 2026



Lansing Democrats introduced legislation Thursday to put limits on automated license plate readers amid a growing public backlash against the technology. It comes after a Senate Republican introduced a bill in July.

"These cameras, they actually collect more than just your license plate number," state Rep. Carrie Rheingans, D-Ann Arbor, told [WNEM](#). "They collect identifying details of the care to make sure it's the right one. They can take picture of the drivers and the other people in the car. They even can keep track of your bumper stickers."

Rheingans is among 13 Democrats and one Republican to sign on in support of [House Bill 6346](#), introduced Thursday by Rep. Matt Koleszar, D-Plymouth.

The legislation would require a court order to send license plate data captured by Flock cameras or other ALPRs to law enforcement agencies outside of Michigan.

"A law enforcement agency in this state shall not share information obtained from captured plate data with another law enforcement agency outside this state unless a court order directs otherwise," the bill reads.

"I think we need to go farther than this bill and make sure that a warrant is always necessary to search this data," Rheingans said, "but this is the bill that's available today."

Rheingans noted HB 6346 is among others introduced recently aimed at limiting who can access ALPR data, and the reasons for searches.

"If you had a crime perpetrated against your or some other issues that you'd be worried that people would be sharing this data, you would know, you would be able to sleep a little easier," she said.

HB 6346 follows House bills 5492 and 5493, introduced in January by Reps. Doug Wozniak, R-Shelby Twp., and Jimmie Wilson, D-Ypsilanti.

The bill package would require ALPR data to be deleted within 30 days without judicial permission to hold longer, and would require law enforcement to publish quarterly reports on the reason for plate searches and data shared with other agencies.

Wozniak and Wilson noted at the time the ALPR systems "risk shifting from targeted investigative tools into broad, ongoing tracking systems that monitor everyday people who are not suspected of wrongdoing."

"Michiganders deserve to know that new technology is being used responsibly, not in ways that invade privacy or erode public confidence," Wozniak said in a [statement](#). "These bills protect the privacy of Michigan motorists while setting clear, commonsense rules that help maintain trust between law enforcement and the public."

State Sen. Jim Runestad, R-White Lake, introduced similar legislation in July with Senate Bill 1131, which would require camera data to be deleted after 14 days, and a warrant for access

to the systems for reasons beyond criminal investigations, or efforts to locate missing persons or stolen vehicles.

"Passively collecting information 24/7 as people go about their daily lives is a drastic overreach and goes well beyond public safety needs," Runestad said in a [statement](#). "This legislation acknowledges that certain emergency situations can be greatly assisted by this technology, but sensible safeguards need to be put in place."

The discussion in Lansing on regulating ALPRs comes amid a widespread public backlash against the technology in Michigan and beyond.

[Recent reports](#) detail investigations into cameras damaged in Orion Township, Commerce Township, Independence Township, Pontiac, Rochester Hills, Novi, Bloomfield Hills, Clarkston, Waterford, Wayne, West Bloomfield, and Kent, Kalamazoo, and Ottawa counties.

"It does absolutely speak to how people feel about this technology and how they feel about being surveilled," Gabrielle Dresner, a policy strategist for the ACLU of Michigan, recently told the [Detroit Free Press](#). "Part of that is the civil liberties concern of having this mass surveillance police state being installed, mostly without any community say or in fact, in opposition to what the community is saying."

The vandalism in Michigan ties into a broader public revolt against a Flock surveillance network of between 80,000 to 100,000 cameras installed across the country that perform more than 20 billion scans per month.

The Washington Post in August documented [at least 50 cases of police officers accessing data for unauthorized purposes](#), including 26 that involved cops spying on their wives, girlfriends, exes, or love interests.

"There is no state law in Michigan governing the use of license plate readers or their public reporting," Dresner told the Free Press. "So this is pretty much up to every municipality or every police department who uses them to kind of make up their own policy or fall back on the internal policy of the company who they are using, which again in this case is Flock."

Beyond camera vandalism, frustrations with ALPRs and the growing surveillance network are motivating more residents to speak out at local government meetings, and fueling [recalls against some local officials](#) who refuse to listen.

In several communities, taxpayers have convinced local leaders to ditch the cameras altogether, including Ferndale, Clawson, Milford, Westland, Sumpter Township, and Oceana County.

Still other communities are considering the same, or working to expand transparency to

address concerns from local residents.

Earlier this month, the Grand Rapids Police Department and Kent County Sheriff's Office launched Flock camera transparency portals to share how often plates are searched, and number of plates scanned over the prior 30 days.

In Kent County, the sheriff's department's 62 Flock cameras conducted 1,012,698 plate scans, producing 11,027 "hotlist alerts," according to the county's [Flock Transparency Portal](#).

Officers conducted 1,306 searches over the past month.

In Grand Rapids, GRPD's 29 flock cameras scanned 506,248 unique plates, producing 10,271 "hotlist hits" over the last 30 days, during which officers conducted 1,044 searches, according to the city's [Flock Transparency Portal](#).

Both portals include narratives on cases in which officers used Flock cameras to solve crimes, agencies the departments shared data with and received data from, as well as the top offense types used for ALPR searches over the prior 30 days.

In Kent County, the top offenses used for searches include larceny, motor vehicle theft, wanted persons, drugs, and obstructing the police, while in GR the top offenses include vehicle theft, wanted persons, obstructing police, drugs, and homicide investigations.

Kent County Sheriff Bryan Muir told [WOOD](#) the technology is helping to crack down on things like retail fraud and other crimes.

"We're recovering a significant amount of property," he said. "We're starting to establish, identification of people that may be continuing in a pattern of crime earlier in that pattern, which we believe is lessening the number of criminal complaints."

There's also protections in place to ensure deputies don't abuse the system, Muir said.

"There's an automated process that automatically triggers if officers are using this technology outside of their normal hours, if they're using this technology to run a repeated plate, there's an automatic trigger that locks their account and flags our administration to review that individual user independently," he explained.